



Rushed return: Harshit Rana's return highlighted the uncomfortable tension between a team's need for a player and the body's need for time.

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are multiple spells, three spells a day of three to four overs each with maximum intensity," a bowling coach, who has trained multiple Indian pacers, tells *Sportstar* on the condition of anonymity.

India pacer Navdeep Saini echoed the point during an interview on the sidelines of the ongoing Delhi Premier League.

"If you want to stay fit, it is important to bowl for long. Nowadays, during normal training, you find bowlers training to bowl just four overs. That won't help. If you have the ability to bowl just four overs in your body, then if you go to play a Test match, how will you bowl 10-15 overs in one day? So, I think the biggest concern among fast bowlers is that they bowl less and train a little more, like doing gym or running," Saini said in a select media interaction.

This misinterpretation leads to mispreparation.

Adrian Le Roux, India's current head of S&C, introduced the Bronco Test as a fitness standard for selection.

This test involves shuttle running over distances of 20, 40, and 60 metres. One run includes shuttling all three distances, which covers 240 metres. A player has to do them five times, totalling 1,200 metres, inside a set limit of around eight minutes to clear this test. The previous standard, the Yoyo Test, also involved shuttle running but was slightly different.

"These are both field tests for establishing basic aerobic conditioning. The Yoyo needs an audio player and has a break/recovery between efforts. It's actually good for mimicking the demands of cricket to some extent. Bronco is continuous effort, change of direction multiple times and is timed. Both are a measure of slightly different parameters and aerobic

sudden jump in their fatigue, so the risk of injury goes up. The holy grail is to find that balance," Leipus says.

It is precisely why national team set-ups obsess over workloads. For instance, Indian players' workload, which includes their training, is recorded. Even their stints with their respective IPL franchises and State franchises are relayed back to the headquarters.

Straying away from the basics?

While Leipus stresses the need for workload management, there is another school of thought that points to a different underlying reason for recurring injuries in players, specifically bowlers.

Strength & Conditioning (S&C) work has trickled into every

cricketer's routine worldwide. It is the direct derivative of high performance. The CoE itself, besides its sprawling cricket grounds and net facilities, also boasts a state-of-the-art gym. Most international teams have a specialised S&C coach to make players stronger and fitter.

However, critics argue this is an approach borrowed from other sports and misinterpreted for cricket, which demands starkly varied physical exertion.

"There's too much conditioning work going on in cricket that looks like doing fitness, but it does not translate to bowling fitness because it is a different energy system than what is needed. What bowlers need